

Human-GenAI Collaboration in Creative Tasks: Creative Industry Perspective

Matilda Kalving

matilda.kalving@tuni.fi

Faculty of Information Technology and Communication Sciences, Tampere University
Tampere, Finland



Figure 1: The shift from conventional job tasks to human-AI collaboration.

Abstract

As GenAI systems scale in complexity, speed, and opacity, the creative industry faces an emerging computational crisis characterized by significant ethical, social, and infrastructural challenges. These emerging systems are actively reshaping creative work by reconfiguring professional roles, transforming creative practices, and altering the tools used in practise, such as design, writing, and production. Despite this, there is a lack of understanding of how creative professionals integrate GenAI into everyday practice and how these systems influence labour, agency, and decision-making. To address this gap, this research investigates how creative practitioners engage with GenAI in-situ and explores how more meaningful and responsible human-AI interaction can be supported. Using a qualitative methodology that combines surveys, participatory workshops, and research-through-design, it examines practitioner experiences, adoption patterns, and evolving creative practices. This work contributes to HCI by mapping and producing both empirical knowledge and prototypes, and design implications.

CCS Concepts

• **Applied computing** → **Arts and humanities**; • **Human-centered computing** → **Interactive systems and tools**.

Keywords

Creative professionals, Human-AI collaboration, Design research methods, Generative AI, Creative support tools

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1 Introduction

In the creative industry, Artificial Intelligence (AI) plays a fundamentally different role than in industries where it replaces repetitive labor [9]. Here, generative AI (GenAI) functions as a support tool or even a potential collaborator that expands creative potential, augments workflows, and enables new forms of expression [13, 22]. However, this shift is not frictionless, as seen in the response from the industry, which has stood up to resist[18] and protest [4], while actively safeguarding human voice, authenticity, and cultural value [2]. These developments raise important questions and prompt a reconsideration of what creativity itself truly means [7].

Creative work has long been shaped by emergent tools [5, 21]. From A4 paper structuring knowledge production [11], to collaborative platforms such as Google Docs enabling real-time co-authoring [20], and presentation software like PowerPoint redefining how knowledge is packaged and interpreted [1], tools have consistently reshaped practice. As computers transformed how people learn, collaborate, and communicate [3]. It is clear that the speed and scale of technological change has intensified, enabling discovery and innovation at an unprecedented pace [22]. GenAI extends this trajectory, reshaping education, research, and creative work [23, 24],



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Figure 2: The research questions guide the investigation of how generative AI is transforming creative tasks, progressing through three key stages: perspectives, workflows, and tool design.

while raising profound questions about the nature and meaning of creativity [7].

The introduction of emerging technologies often surfaces misalignment between the values embedded in GenAI development and those of practitioners [10]. Similarly, HCI research often introduces systems with limited acknowledgment or analysis of their historical foundations. In contrast, creative and literary fields actively draw on and reference their rich histories [6]. This gap highlights the need to reconsider how creativity-support tools are framed and designed, moving beyond prioritizing efficiency, productivity, and output quality[8] to include broader dimensions such as self-reflection, agency, and well-being [19]. Existing studies tend to focus either on high-level ethical, economic, or cultural implications of generative AI, or on isolated tool capabilities, without sufficiently addressing how creative professionals meaningfully integrate GenAI into everyday practice. Consequently, there is limited empirical and design-oriented guidance on how perspectives, workflows, and tool affordances interact to support creative agency rather than undermine its core structures and values.

To address this gap and the limited empirical and design-oriented guidance on how perspectives, workflows, and tool affordances interact to support creative agency, I adopt a three-layered approach encompassing perspectives, workflow-to-practice, and tool design, as illustrated in Figure 2. The goal is to develop practical frameworks and design principles that enable the effective integration of generative AI into creative workflows, contributing both to academic discourse and real-world industry practices.

2 Research Focus and Questions

The project adopts a three-layered practice centered lens focused on: (1) practitioner perspectives, (2) workflows and creative practice, and (3) tool design, as seen in figure 2. By foregrounding practice and AI-intervention across these layers, the lens is operationalized through the following research questions:

- (1) **What are the expectations and early experiences of creative industry professionals regarding the use of GenAI tools in their creative processes?** Exploring how professionals perceive and engage with GenAI tools, focusing on initial expectations, early reactions, and the challenges or opportunities that emerge during adoption.
- (2) **How do GenAI tools shape the creative processes, roles, and division of labor within the creative industry?** Examining how these tools influence decision-making, creative workflows, and practice.
- (3) **What kinds of GenAI tools support a positive user experience for creative professionals?** Identifying design

features that enhance user satisfaction and the quality of creative output, contributing to the development of tools that fit more intuitively into creative practice.

Table 1: Research publication list, please note some titles are hidden as they are currently under peer review or preparation.

#	Reference	Status
1	Matilda Kalving, Ashley Colley, and Jonna Häkkinen. 2024. <i>Where AI and Design Meet: Designers' Perceptions of AI Tools</i> . In Proceedings of the 13th Nordic Conference on Human-Computer Interaction (NordiCHI '24). Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, Article 52, 1–8. https://doi.org/10.1145/3679318.3685388	Published
2	Matilda Kalving, Kaisa Väänänen, Thomas Olsson. 2026. <i>Real Title Hidden: Professional Writers + GenAI</i>	In review
3	Matilda Kalving, Amir Pakpour Haji Agha, Thomas Olsson, Kaisa Väänänen. 2026. <i>Real Title Hidden: Collaborative GenAI Assessment</i>	In review
4	Matilda Kalving, Kaisa Väänänen. 2027. <i>Real Title Hidden: Design + Imperfections + GenAI</i>	In preparation
5	Matilda Kalving, Kaisa Väänänen. 2027. <i>Real Title Hidden: Embodied and Tangible GenAI in Creative Industry</i>	In preparation

3 Methods

The research follows a qualitative, research-through-design (RtD) approach, combining:

- (1) Surveys and interviews with creative professionals
- (2) Participatory workshops exploring real-world GenAI use
- (3) Design explorations and speculative prototypes

This approach enables close engagement with practitioners' lived experiences and supports iterative reflection between empirical insights and design practice. RtD is used not only as a method for generating artifacts, but as a way of surfacing values, tensions, and breakdowns in human-AI interaction. The goal is to develop practical frameworks and design principles that support the effective integration of GenAI into creative workflows, contributing both to academic discourse and to industry practices.

Findings from this research will be shared at academic conferences and published in peer-reviewed journals, as seen in table 1. They will also be discussed for peer feedback in workshops [15, 17], and doctoral consortiums [12], as shown in figure 2. The insights, design discussions, and prototypes developed through this work aim to improve the effectiveness of creative practices, reshape perceptions of AI, and advance understanding of human-AI collaboration. These contributions provide both theoretical insights and practical applications, enriching discussions around the evolving role of generative AI in creative industries



Figure 3: Creativity in the Imperfections position paper exploring the tension between the designer's vision and the AI's output, and how this design friction can steer the creative process in unforeseen directions.

4 Emerging Insights & Contributions

Early findings indicate that GenAI introduces both productive and disruptive dynamics in creative work [13, 15, 17]. Designers in *Where AI and Design Meet* report benefits such as faster ideation and broader creative exploration [13]. These dynamics were further examined in *Creativity in the Imperfections* (Figure 3) [17] and will be revisited in 2026. However, other works, including *Professional Creative Writing + GenAI* and *Navigating Friction between GenAI and Creative Professionals*, highlight persistent sources of friction. These include reduced authorship clarity, a diminished sense of control, and ethical ambiguity surrounding ownership and consent [14, 18].

These moments of friction reveal where existing tools fail to align with creative values and professional identities, pointing toward alternative design directions that foreground transparency, agency, and reflective use[15]. Rather than framing these tensions as failures, the research has explored treating them as productive sites for design intervention [16]. Ongoing work extends this investigation into novel emerging design methodologies and embodied creative practices, including the use of AI as a medium for creative sensemaking. Particular attention is given to ethical implications and professional agency. The research aims to inform both HCI research and the design of future creative support systems.

5 Conclusion

This doctoral research addresses an emerging computational crisis in creative industries as generative AI becomes embedded in everyday creative work. Rather than treating GenAI as a purely technical system, the project foregrounds lived creative practice and examines how GenAI reshapes creative decisions, roles, and divisions of labor. Through a research-through-design approach combining surveys, participatory workshops, and design explorations, the work aims to develop conceptual frameworks and design principles that support meaningful and responsible human–GenAI interaction, particularly around creative agency, consent, authorship, and ownership.

Participation in the CHI 2026 Student Mentoring Program Dissertation Research Roundtable is timely for this project. As the dissertation has moved from early studies (e.g., designers' perceptions and design friction) into expanded investigations of professional creative writing and embodied creative practices towards its final

Table 2: Published Position & Workshop papers

#	Reference	Status
1	Matilda Kalving, Kaisa Väänänen, Thomas Olsson. 2024. <i>Creativity in the Imperfections: GenAI as a Disruptive Inspiration</i> . Designing with AI –workshop in conjunction with Nordic Conference on Human-Computer Interaction (NordiCHI 2024). Association for Computing Machinery, New York, NY, USA, Article 52, 1–8. https://doi.org/10.1145/3679318.3685388	Published
2	Kalving, Matilda, and Kaisa Väänänen. <i>Navigating Friction between GenAI and Creative Professionals: Recognising Stop Signs and Surfacing Values</i> . Third Workshop on Design Research & GenAI at ACM Designing Interactive Systems Conference (DIS) 2025.	Published
3	Matilda Kalving. 2025. <i>Human-GenAI Collaboration in Creative Tasks: Creative Industry Perspective</i> . Doctoral Consortium at the sixth decennial Aarhus conference: Computing X Crisis, Aug 2025, Aarhus, Denmark. (hal-05191047)	Published

papers. As such, the Roundtable offers an opportunity to strengthen the coherence of the dissertation argument across domains and methods. Specifically, I seek feedback on (1) positioning the dissertation's contributions within CHI conversations on creative support tools and industry practice, (2) articulating research-through-design contributions in a way that is legible across audiences, and (3) refining the scope of the dissertation to ensure the resulting frameworks and principles are both grounded and actionable for future tool design.

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